

REG_SZ: “REG_SZ” stands for “String Value”, and represents data as a string of characters. This string can be a word, a number, or the location of a file on the hard drive. REG_SZ is the second-most edited value while hacking the Registry.

8.4.3 Editing The Registry

Before you start editing the registry, it is always advisable to back up the current registry and save it to your hard drive. This is important because you might do something wrong and your computer could even stop functioning—in which case you’ll need to bring back the old Registry.

8.4.3.1 Creating A Registry Backup

Launch the Registry Editor, and select File > Export. In the subsequent dialog box, enter a name for the Registry file, say “Before_Editing”, and select a location to store the file, say ‘My Documents’. Before you press ‘OK’, select the ‘All’ option at the bottom of the page so that the entire registry is saved rather than the selected branch.

There are two types of registry files, a .REG file and a Hive file. If you save your current registry as a .REG file, then during restoration, it will simply add the information to the Registry without overwriting the new entries. But in the case of a Registry going bad due to installation of malware, it becomes necessary to overwrite the entire Registry, in which case the Hive file comes in handy. So when you’re taking a Registry backup, make sure you save it in both formats. This can be done by selecting the file type as “.REG” or “Hive” in the ‘Save As’ dialog box.

8.4.3.2 Restoring A Registry

Restoring a Registry gone bad is simple. Open REGEDIT and go to File > Import. In the box that opens, browse to the backup file; it could be a .REG file or a Hive file. Select the appropriate file and press ‘OK’. The system might ask you to provide your username and password.